

effects are replaced by the accumulated effects of your life experience as an adult.

This should be good news for those who haven't been brought up in a perfect microcosm of wealth enhancing childhood experiences. Which, let's face it, is many of us. In fact, the sum of all these studies should offer hope by suggesting that the die isn't cast by your childhood experiences—instead, one of the most significant factors is your changing experience over time.

But don't just take my word for it. Let's look at what is possibly one of the most comprehensive research investigations into human development, the Dunedin Study, which I mentioned in the previous chapter. The Dunedin Study agrees with this finding that we aren't fixed and have the ability to change our behaviour and therefore our experience.

For nearly 50 years, Terrie Moffitt and Avshalom Caspi have followed the lives of 1037 babies born between 1 April 1972 and 31 March 1973 at Queen Mary Maternity Hospital, Dunedin, New Zealand. The study started at birth and continues even today. The children were studied at the age of 3, assessed every two years until the age of 15 and then assessed at the ages of 18, 21, 26, 32, 38 and 45. The study focuses on a range of things from family health to identifying the social and family determinants of a parenting style, to how the participants parent themselves, to the lifestyles, behaviours, attitudes and health of the participants today compared to when they were 15, in 1987–88.

The Dunedin Study supports the idea of nurture over nature, that we are not fixed in our personalities and circumstances, but have a level of self-determination in the course of our lives. Among the most important findings was one particular ability that we can teach any child or adult, regardless of their upbringing or personality, which will directly and positively impact their future financial, physical and emotional health.

That ability is self-control.

Perhaps the definitive and certainly the most well-known self-control test is the Marshmallow Test. During this test, a single marshmallow is placed on a plate in front of a young child who is then left alone in a room. The adult tells the child clearly in advance that if they can refrain from eating the first marshmallow before the adult's return, there will be a reward in the form of a second marshmallow.